

YouCred

An online tool co-designed with fact-checkers for misinformation discovery on YouTube

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THE PROBLEM

YouTube is a blind spot for fact-checkers

World's second-largest search engine

A hub for conspiracy theories, fact-checkers say.

Few affordances for the work

No trending view; claims are buried inside long videos.

Tools exist for Facebook and X

Nothing comparable is adopted for video.

"YouTube is one of our blind spots... we don't have access or visibility to YouTube unless you go and manually use the search button."

— Pesacheck fact-checker

Process of Finding misinformation on YouTube is unstructured

- Conducted 11 formative interviews with fact-checkers at Pesacheck.

CURRENT CHALLENGES → NEEDS

Search is manual & based on guesswork

Fact-checkers guess terms until something dubious surfaces.

↓ A structured & automated way to search

No way to track many searches

One query at a time, with no analytics to compare results.

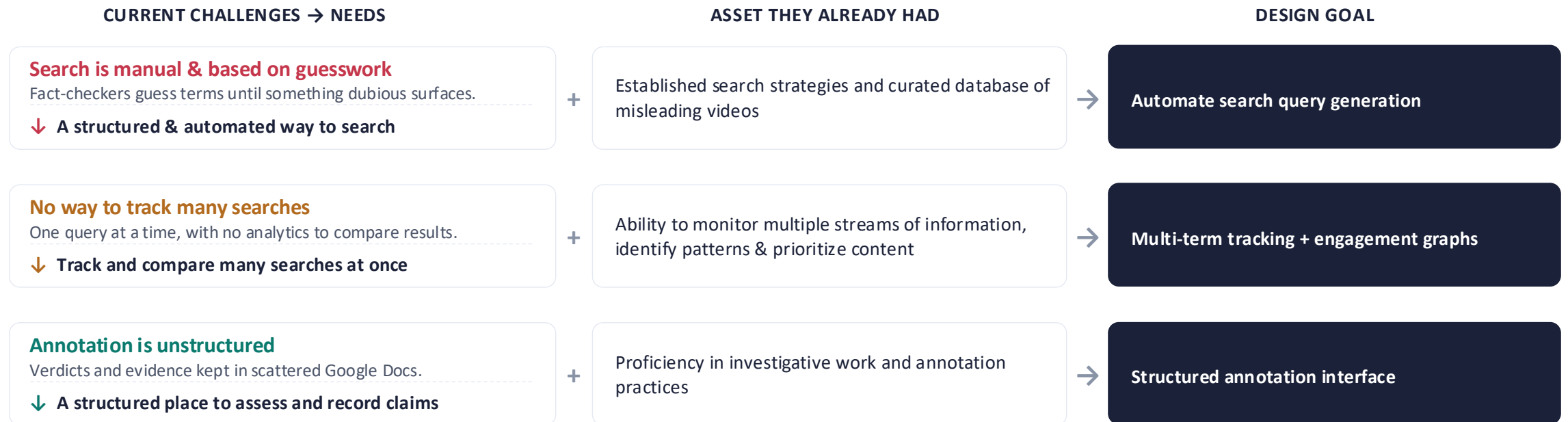
↓ Track and compare many searches at once

Annotation is unstructured

Verdicts and evidence kept in scattered Google Docs.

↓ A structured place to assess and record claims

Design around needs, build on assets

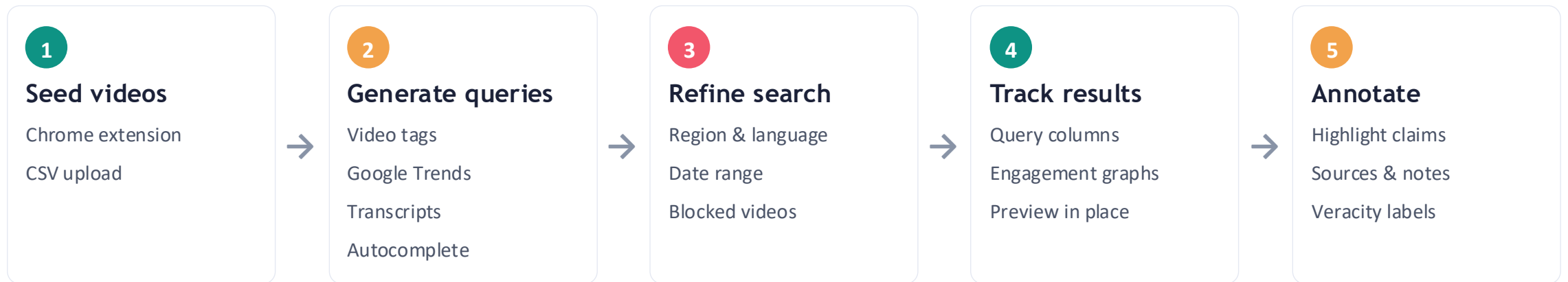


Two years of building with Pesacheck

System built: YouCred



YouCred at a glance



Human in the loop — every query is editable; every verdict is the fact-checker's call.

Four lenses for generating search queries

Video tags

Creator metadata; exposes the narratives creators attach to a topic.

Google Trends

Top and rising YouTube searches; low-volume terms expose data voids.

Transcripts

TF-IDF terms from seed transcripts; catches claims tags miss.

Autocomplete

What YouTube suggests.

Fact-checkers stay in control: no default method, and every suggested term can be added, edited, or removed before a search runs.

Video tags expose conspiracy vocabulary around a topic

YouTube Video Tags: Select tags for Ebola

Select one or more frequently occurring video tags extracted from the provided videos to generate search queries*
The number next to each keyword is its frequency count.

Select minimum frequency number Sort tags ▾

alternative media 1 + abc 2 + nwo 2 + new world order 1 + agenda21 1 + enemy of the nwo 1 + enemy of the new world order 1 ✓
red pill revolution 1 ✓ breaking new 1 + breaking 1 + cash in hand 1 + bbc 1 + vaccine (drug class) 1 + illuminati 2 ✓ corrupt 1 ✓
government 1 + obama 1 + ww3 1 + ufo 1 + dahboo77 1 + bible 1 + black 1 + hebrew 1 + african 1 + jesus 1 +
barack obama (us president) 1 + black (ethnicity) 1 + population control 1 ✓ aid 1 + created 1 + destroy 1 + gay 1 + umar johnson 1 +

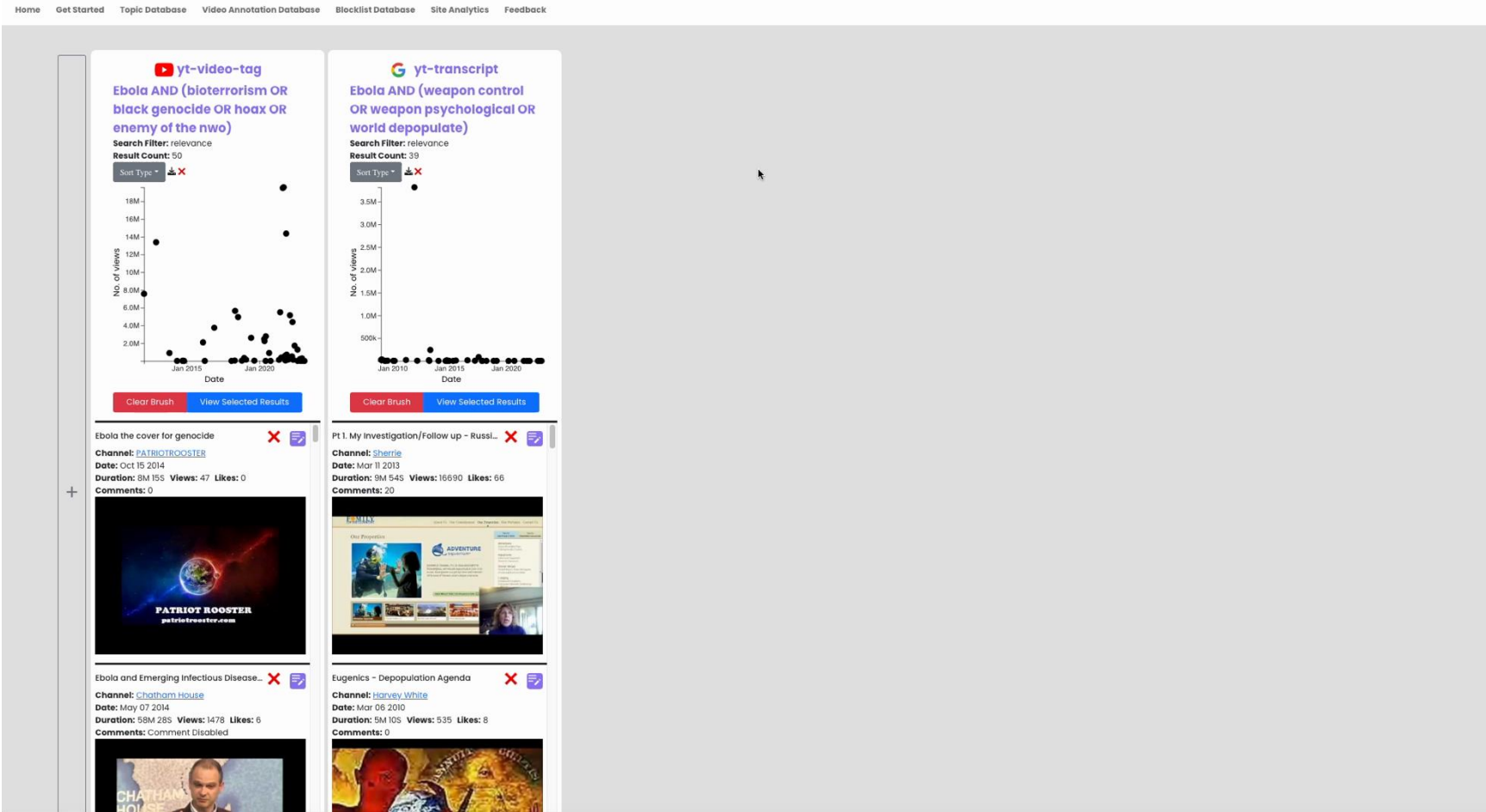
Generated YouTube Search Query*
You may edit the generated search query as you wish.

Ebola AND ("red pill revolution" OR "enemy of the new world order" OR "illuminati" OR "corrupt" OR "population control")

"I would have searched Ebola with health, Africa, pandemic - not necessarily New World Order, or Illuminati."

— 17

Track many queries side by side



Structured credibility assessment in one place

(1) CURE FOR ALL TYPES OF CANCER, THE SECRET IS IN HOT WATER WITH SLICES OF PINEAPPLE

False



01:47 start taking thank you so much
01:51 hot pineapple releases anti anti-a
01:53 cancer substances the latest advancement
01:56 in medicine for effective cancer
01:58 treatment
01:59 the warm fruit of pineapple has the
02:01 effect of killing cysts and tumors
02:04 it has been proven to cure all types of
02:06 cancer
02:07 pineapple hot water clears all the germs
02:10 and toxins from the body due to
02:12 allergies
02:14 a drug derived from pineapple juice only
02:16 destroys a violent cells and does
02:19 not affect healthy cells also the amino
02:23 acids and pineapple polyphenols in
02:25 pineapple juice can control high blood
02:27 pressure prevent blockage of internal
02:30 blood vessels improve blood sugar
02:37 don't forget
02:38 everything

Annotations

Time Stamp: 01:59 Delete

Comments:
Research done on Bromelain, a group of enzymes found in

Sources:
<https://medium.com/pesa-check/false-hot-pineapple->

Conclusion:
False

Tags:

Highlight claims

In transcript, subtitles, title or description.

Evidence per claim

Comments, sources, a verdict, and tags.

Claims database

Spot recurring narratives and repeat spreaders.

Nine months in a working newsroom

124

seed videos
uploaded, mostly
via the extension

45

videos assessed for
credibility

9 mo

Sep 2022 - May
2023

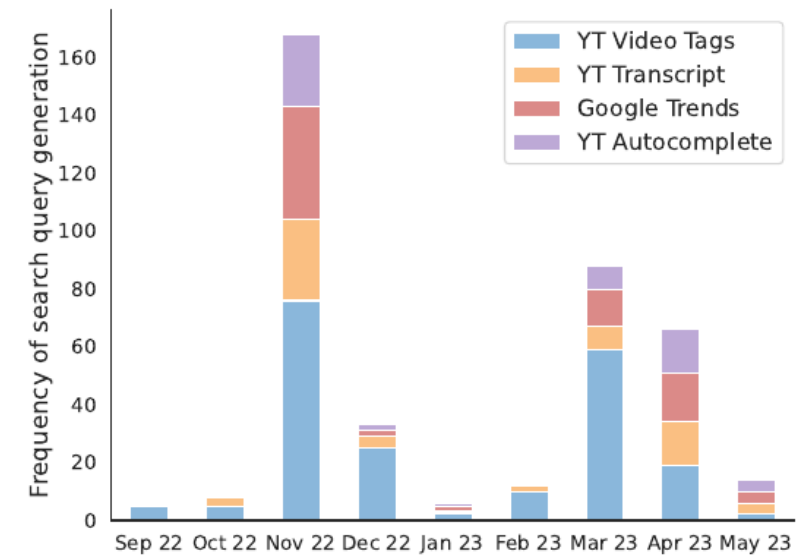
TOPICS MONITORED

Ebola

Kenyan elections

Countering violent extremism

FIFA World Cup



Query generations per month, by method

What fact-checkers told us

"A pool of information that would otherwise not be available if we were generating queries manually."

I4 · on query suggestions

"We spend less time getting misinfo as opposed to when we were searching on YouTube directly"

I5 · on efficiency

"I don't have to document it on Google Docs. You can do all of that within the tool itself."

I7 · on annotation

Deployment surfaced new constraints

Platform API quotas

10,000 requests/day; one query could exhaust it, pausing work 24h - even during elections.

Seeding is labor

Curating seeds is taxing; they want seeds from tiplines and cross-platform trends.

Noise remains

Authoritative videos still crowd results; future work ranks by likelihood of misinformation.

Needs keep evolving. A deployed system has to keep adapting.

Takeaways

- 1 Video platforms should support fact-checking.
- 2 Design around what organizations already have, not just what they lack.
- 3 Deployment isn't the finish line — socio-technical systems need ongoing maintenance, and that work must be resourced.

Thank you

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